Some of You Think You're Too Cool

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📋 Executive Summary

Greg Lav chronicles Bloom Energy's #1 TikTok Shop achievement and the Big Apple NYC event while delivering blunt entrepreneurship advice: stop being too cool to market yourself, launch fast, hire hungry people, and stack consistent days.

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🍓 Strawberry Shorty Goes #1 on TikTok Shop 0:21

- Strawberry Shorty becomes **#1 on all of TikTok Shop** — not just beverages or energy drinks, but the entire platform
  - Greg claims to have proof from TikTok Shop corporate
- Critics DMed him saying it was a "summer flavor" and shouldn't launch in October
  - Greg's rebuttal: if you have a good idea, launch it as fast as possible regardless of season
  - "Patience is an entrepreneur's worst energy"
- He calls it already a "massive record-breaking flavor" and predicts it will be the hottest energy drink of 2026
- Bloom went from struggling to sell 1,000 Bloom cases to projecting **1 million Bloom cases** delivered that year

🍏 The Big Apple Event in NYC 1:29

- Event themed around Crisp Apple energy drink in New York City — a play on "Big Apple"
  - Crisp Apple launched August 2025 and remains Bloom's **#1 best-selling flavor** over a year later
- Event structure:
  - Friday night: VIP event for strategic partners and top creators — dress code is all red, Crisp Apple themed
  - Saturday and Sunday: open consumer event projected at **4,000–6,000 attendees** lining up down the street
- Consumer event offerings:
  - Free gifts, free energy drinks, free snacks
  - Live DJ on set the entire weekend
- Venue features included: DJ booth, extensive merch, a full cocktail bar serving alcohol, a giant Crisp Apple photo booth
- Event philosophy shift:
  - Previously did many smaller events throughout the year
  - Now prefers **4–6 large, high-budget events** open for 4–5 days each rather than many smaller "lemonade stand" activations

🧪 Sampling Unreleased Flavors to Survey Consumers 2:58

- The activation Greg calls the most exciting at the entire event: a blind tasting booth with **anonymous (unlabeled) cans**
- Five unreleased, polarizing flavors being tested:
  - Golden Kiwi
  - Strawberry Acai
  - Mango Cream
  - Pineapple Passion Fruit (noted: Greg hates pineapple)
  - Raspberry Grapefruit
- Consumers rank the flavors and vote on which should be #1
- Consumers also describe their dream flavor — name, fruits, combinations — and Bloom may actually make it
- Why this method works:
  - Online surveys or emails asking "what flavors do you want?" don't work well — people don't know what they want until they taste it
  - Example: someone might think they wouldn't like golden kiwi in an energy drink, but after tasting it they might love it
  - Many of Bloom's 2026 flavors came directly from doing this exact in-person tasting experience

> The only way to efficiently survey consumers on what they want in 2027 is live, in-person blind tasting — not Shopify surveys or emails.

😎 Red Flag: Being Too Cool to Market Yourself 4:10

- Greg's #1 red flag for new entrepreneurs: being nonchalant or "too cool" to promote your own business
- Specific behaviors he calls out:
  - Too cool to post in your Instagram/social story
  - Too cool to have a branded pink truck driving around
  - Not willing to post about your product every single day
- His stance: "I'm not too cool for this stuff" — he posts about his products daily without embarrassment
- The implication: entrepreneurship is a high-risk bet on yourself, and being reserved about marketing is self-sabotage
  - "You're risking your life to go after entrepreneurship and you're too cool to post in your story. Stay home, fam."

📈 Stacking Consistent Days Over Adrenaline Moments 5:22

- The right question to ask daily: "What do I do today that's going to double my business?"
- Growth doesn't come from one amazing adrenaline-rush day — it comes from **consistent decent days stacking up**
- What sets you back:
  - Hangovers eating up days
  - Distractions like chasing relationships that don't matter
  - These individually small losses compound negatively over a year
- Bloom's 10-year growth chart analogy:
  - Zoomed in, it looks like no growth at all
  - Zoomed out, the compounding is dramatic — "that's because you're just stacking days"
- The edge: accumulating more productive days than your competitor, even if each day only moves you slightly forward

🚀 Advice for Early-Stage Founders 6:08

- Two young founders building a product-based business trying to break into the protein market asked Greg for advice
- Their biggest bottleneck: settling on a product and executing
- Key insight on launches:
  - You don't always know something is a great idea when you launch it

    - Bloom has **pivoted 300 times**
    - Build a brand flexible enough to follow where culture leads — don't lock yourself into one rigid product category
    - Counter-example: RX Bar — the name tethered them to bars only
    - Choose a brand name with platform capability (room to expand)
- On using the algorithm as a signal:
    - If something isn't getting traction on Instagram or TikTok, people don't want it — the algorithm doesn't lie
- Launch strategy recommendation:
    - Don't launch with 10 things, but don't launch with just 1 either
    - Launch with **at least 3 slight variations** (e.g., one bar chocolate-covered, one plain, one crunchy)
    - Only one will likely work, but it gives you directional signal on where to invest energy
    - Counter-example: Red Bull launched with one flavor — don't do that
- On acquisition vs. retention:
    - Early in career: focus entirely on **mastering acquisition** — become world-class at getting new customers
    - Don't optimize for retention before you're huge — solve churn later
    - Greg's experience: Bloom now has great retention AND mastered acquisition, but he built acquisition first
    - "Don't optimize heavily before you're f***ing huge"
- On niche cultural marketing:
    - For the wrestler-founder: identify a big cultural wrestling moment (e.g., 2027 or 2028 Olympics) and build a limited-edition product timed to that event
    - The algorithm will amplify content around that cultural moment organically
- On targeted PR:
    - Sometimes it's not about how many people you market to, but **who** sees it
    - Greg still invests in traditional PR (e.g., Wall Street Journal placements) because influential decision-makers still read legacy media — "the Illuminati still reads the Wall Street Journal"
    - Billboards in strategic locations where the right people will see them

🏢 Hiring Strategy and Building Team Culture 9:12

- Early hires: Greg's best early hires were his best friend and his mom — people he could **trust** first, skills second
- Talent acquisition method:
    - Found impressive people posting about relevant topics online and cold-messaged them: "Yo bro, I'm building something really cool. I think you might be interested."
    - Also benefited from inbound interest — people who reached out saying they believed in what he was building
- What he prioritizes in hiring:

    - **Passion and hunger over skills** in early stages — "you can teach skills"
- On keeping employees motivated:
    - If they're not hungry from the start, that's a concern
    - Don't give feedback directly — **lead by example**
    - Show up on time, don't come in hungover, stay locked in — employees will mirror what they see
- Office culture:
    - Strongly advocates for **in-person offices** — against fully remote companies scaling fast
    - "I've always been an in-person culture company"
    - Would create a physical office even if you don't have one yet
- On handling business crises:
    - Instinct is to respond immediately — but that's a mistake
    - Depending on the severity: take a shower, go for a walk, sleep on it
    - Don't reply to the email right away — emotional responses lead to mistakes or saying things you regret
    - Come back the next morning with a fresh mind, even if you don't sleep well

🔥 All-In Mindset and Timing 10:40

- When to go all in depends on your personal risk tolerance
- Whatever environment you need to go all in — create that environment
- Key point: if you're not 100% committed, you're competing against people who are
- Caveat: if going all-in too fast makes you nervous, you can't operate well under that pressure
    - Don't create a situation where anxiety paralyzes you — find your threshold

👟 Personal Brand Speed Run: 10K Followers in 88 Days 11:23

- A firefighter at the event credited Greg's advice from 3 months prior
    - Greg had said in a video: the most powerful thing you can do in 2026 if you have nothing going on is build your personal brand
- Results in 88 days (less than 3 months):
    - **10,000 followers gained**
    - Posting cadence: 1 post per day + 3 trial reels per day
    - One video hit **1.9 million views** — described as Greg's all-time record
- Greg highlights trial reels as a particularly powerful growth tool
- The firefighter implemented everything Greg advised and said his business "genuinely 10x'd"

🧃 16-Year-Old Founder Sells Out 5,000 Bottles Organically 11:51

- A 16-year-old wrestler at the event built an all-natural hydration product:

    - Made it in a commercial kitchen
    - Sold **5,000 bottles direct-to-consumer**
    - Zero paid ads — entirely organic through videos online
    - Most viewed video: approaching a random person on the street (~5,000 likes) — that single video sold him out completely
- Now has a $100,000 investor and is planning his first production run
    - Has already spent ~$15,000 on manufacturing; bank account at zero
- Greg's advice to him:
    - Find a big cultural wrestling moment (2027 or 2028 Olympics)
    - Build a limited-edition product or flavor timed to that moment
    - The algorithm will be saturated with wrestling content around that event — ride that wave
    - Focus on **acquisition first**, not retention — become a master of getting new customers before worrying about keeping them

🏙️ Scouting Bloom's New NYC Headquarters 13:19

- After the weekend event, the Bloom team toured potential NYC office spaces in Soho
- Vision escalation:
    - Started as a "small satellite office" concept
    - Quickly grew into full **New York headquarters** ambitions — "classic Bloom fashion"
- Key criteria Greg wants:
    - **Move-in ready** — does not want to spend 6 months on construction or tenant improvements
    - Worried he'll get obsessed with perfecting interior details ("making sure the B logo is on the toilet bowl perfectly") instead of doing real work
    - Large windows for natural light — specifically noted as important for creators on the team
- First space visited: hard no — would require 6 months of construction
- Preferred option: a second-floor space with high ceiling heights and large windows
    - Real estate agent noted second floors in buildings often have better specs because they were originally built for retail
    - Greg noted it felt more creative than other options
    - Budget discussed: $100K/month, with questions about what $150K/month could get
- Side moment: Greg randomly encountered the dog he had previously rescued in Austin, Texas, at the office tour location — described as a surreal coincidence
- Greg reflects on being back in the area where he used to commute unpaid from Westchester, NY for a philanthropy t-shirt brand internship he eventually quit — "very weird to be back looking for an office space. I never expected to be doing this in my life."